

A JPP RESOURCE COLLECTION GUIDE

THE JUNIOR DETECTIVE OBSERVATION KIT

Inspired by The Adventures of D.D. & Reuel

A reusable mystery-solving activity guide for young readers



Observe · Question · Record · Investigate · Explain



Every Mystery Begins With a Question

D.D. and Reuel know that mysteries can begin anywhere: at home, in a garden, around the neighborhood, at a community event, or in a place where something simply does not seem quite right.

Good detectives do not immediately decide what happened. They slow down. They look carefully. They ask questions. They record what they notice. Then they use the clues to build an explanation.

In this kit, YOU are the detective.

Five Detective Habits

- | | | |
|----------|--------------------|--|
| 1 | OBSERVE | What do I actually see, hear, or notice? |
| <hr/> | | |
| 2 | QUESTION | What do I need to know? |
| <hr/> | | |
| 3 | RECORD | What information should I write down? |
| <hr/> | | |
| 4 | INVESTIGATE | How can I learn more? |
| <hr/> | | |
| 5 | EXPLAIN | What do the clues tell me? |

JUNIOR DETECTIVE PLEDGE

I will look carefully, ask thoughtful questions, follow the clues, and never confuse a guess with a fact.

JUNIOR DETECTIVE SIGNATURE _____

OBSERVATION CHALLENGE

What Do You Notice?

Detectives train their eyes to notice details other people may miss.

Study the picture for **30 seconds**. Then cover it and answer the questions without looking back.



TIME'S UP? TURN THE PAGE.

What Did You See?

Answer from memory. Then turn back and check your answers.

For grown-ups: fill in the blanks before the detective begins, choosing different details each time so the picture can be used again and again.

How many _____ did you see?

What color was _____?

Where was the _____?

What object seemed out of place?

What detail did you notice that someone else might miss?

MY SCORE: I remembered _____ out of _____ details correctly.

DETECTIVE LESSON

Looking and observing are not always the same thing.

Fact, Clue, or Guess?

A detective must know the difference between what is known, what may help solve the mystery, and what has not yet been proven.

FACT

Something known or directly observed.

CLUE

Information that may help explain what happened.

GUESS

Something we think might be true but have not proven.

Practice

A gate that was closed earlier is now open.

☐ FACT ☐ CLUE ☐ GUESS

A fresh footprint appears beside the path.

☐ FACT ☐ CLUE ☐ GUESS

Someone says, "I heard a noise near the shed."

☐ FACT ☐ CLUE ☐ GUESS

The person near the shed must have caused the problem.

☐ FACT ☐ CLUE ☐ GUESS

A small object is found where it does not normally belong.

☐ FACT ☐ CLUE ☐ GUESS

IMPORTANT

A good detective can have a hunch. A good detective also knows a hunch isn't proof.

Build Your Own Case File

CASE NAME: _____

WHAT HAPPENED?

WHEN? _____

WHERE? _____

PEOPLE INVOLVED:

WHAT I OBSERVED:

Clues I Found

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Questions I Still Have

Follow the Evidence

CLUE	WHERE I FOUND IT	WHAT IT MIGHT MEAN	FACT OR GUESS?

Most Important Clue

I think the most important clue is _____

because _____

DETECTIVE TIP

Strong detectives explain why a clue matters.

Words Every Junior Detective Should Know

OBSERVE

to look or notice carefully

EVIDENCE

information or objects that help show what happened

INVESTIGATE

to examine something carefully to discover facts

SUSPECT

a person thought possibly connected to what happened

MOTIVE

a reason someone might do something

WITNESS

a person who saw or heard something

THEORY

an explanation based on the information you have

DETAIL

a small but important piece of information

CONCLUSION

a decision reached after considering the evidence

VERIFY

to check that something is true or accurate

Try It

Choose one word. Write what you thought it meant before reading the definition, then use it in a sentence.

Word: _____

What I thought it meant: _____

My sentence: _____

The Case of the Moved Garden Marker

One morning in Pleasantville, a small wooden marker that normally stands beside the community garden path is found several feet away near a bench. Nothing is broken, and nothing is missing.

Witness Statements

Ms. Carter

"The wind was strong last night, but that marker usually stays in place."

A neighbor

"I saw children playing near the path yesterday afternoon."

A gardener

"There were fresh wheel tracks beside the garden this morning."

Clues

Check off each clue as you think about it.

- ☐ The marker is lightweight.
- ☐ There are fresh wheel tracks near its usual location.
- ☐ A garden cart is parked beside the bench.
- ☐ The marker has a small scrape along one edge.
- ☐ Nothing else in the garden has been disturbed.

Your Investigation

What do you think happened to the marker?

Your Investigation

The Case of the Moved Garden Marker

Which clue helped you most?

What else would you want to investigate before deciding?

Which information might be unrelated to what happened?

Sketch the Scene

*Draw the garden path, the bench, and the cart. Mark where the marker usually stands with an **X** and where it was found with a **?***



Your Adventure Detective Page

Use this page while reading any D.D. & Reuel adventure, or with a mystery of your own.

Book or mystery title: _____

What is the main mystery?

Three clues I noticed:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Something I first thought was important but changed my mind about:

My theory:

What evidence supports my theory?

Was my theory correct? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ I need more evidence

DETECTIVE RULE

It is okay to change your theory when the evidence changes.

Now You Be the Mystery Writer

Every detective needs a mystery. Every mystery needs a storyteller.

Mystery title: _____

Something is missing, changed, or unusual:

Where does it happen? _____

Who discovers it? _____

Three Clues

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

One clue that might distract the detective:

What really happened?

WRITER'S CHALLENGE

Make sure your mystery can be solved using the clues you provide.

CERTIFICATE OF ACHIEVEMENT

OFFICIAL

JUNIOR DETECTIVE

This certifies that

has successfully completed the

JPP Junior Detective Observation Kit

and demonstrated the ability to

Observe Carefully · Ask Questions · Record Clues
Investigate Evidence · Explain Conclusions

Date: _____ Junior Detective Case No.: _____

Parent / Teacher / Librarian: _____

D.D. & REUEL DETECTIVE BUREAU — PLEASANTVILLE



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THE CASE CONTINUES

Keep Looking Closely

Mysteries are everywhere, waiting for someone curious enough to notice them.

Every time you slow down, look carefully, ask a good question, and let the evidence lead the way, you are thinking like a detective. Keep your notebook close. The next mystery might be right outside your door.

Observe · Question · Record · Investigate · Explain

Keep Learning

Find more complimentary guides, activities, and educational materials in the JPP Resource Center.

[[Resource Center link](#)]



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